

Proteles cristata

Aardwolf



Length 22–32 in
(55–80 cm)

Tail 8–12 in
(20–30 cm)

Weight 18–31 lb
(8–14 kg)

Location E. and southern
Africa

Social unit Individual

Status Least concern



A small relative of the hyena, the aardwolf's specialized diet is termites, particularly surface-foraging nasute (snouted) harvester termites. It also licks up maggots, grubs, and other small, soft-bodied creatures. Its longer

front legs and down-sloping body are accentuated by the crestlike back mane, most prominent on the neck and shoulders. This erects under stress so the animal appears larger. The fur is pale buff or yellow-white with 3 vertical stripes on each side, and diagonal stripes across the fore- and hindquarters. The front teeth are hyena-like but the molars are small pegs, the food being ground up by the muscular stomach. The aardwolf is solitary and nocturnal, resting in a burrow by day. It marks its territory with urine, dung, and anal gland secretions. The 1–4 cubs are born after a gestation period of 90 days, emerge from the den at 4 weeks, forage with the mother from 9–11 weeks, and are weaned by 16 weeks.

*Parahyaena brunnea*

Brown hyena



Length 43–51 ft
(1.1–1.36 m)

Tail 7½–10¼ in
(18.5–26.5 cm)

Weight 63–105 lb
(28.5–47.5 kg)

Location Southern Africa

Social unit Variable

Status Near threatened



This species ranges farther into deserts than other hyenas, and can scent carrion from 8½ miles (14 km). It has the typical hyena's powerful jaws and shearing teeth for scavenging on any carcass, including seal pups along the Namib Desert coast. It also catches prey such as springhares. The brown hyena forms loose clans that defend their territory. Its coat is shaggy, dark brown to black, with a pale tawny neck mantle, a gray-patched face, and striped legs.

*Hyaena hyaena*

Striped hyena



Length 3¼–3½ ft
(1–1.15 m)

Tail 12–16 in
(30–40 cm)

Weight 57–90 lb
(26–41 kg)

Location W., N., and E.
Africa, W. to S. Asia

Social unit Individual/Group

Status Near threatened



Preferring savanna and open woodland, this hyena avoids extreme habitats such as deserts. It is gray or pale brown with 5–6 vertical flank bars. The neck mane lessens on the back and merges with the bushy black-and-white tail. Generally solitary, this hyena may form a family group when breeding. It scavenges, hunts prey from insects to hares, and eats fruit and other plant matter.



dark brown
or black
throat patch

Crocuta crocuta

Spotted hyena



Length 4–5¼ ft
(1.25–1.6 m)

Tail 9–10½ in
(22–27 cm)

Weight 99–190 lb
(45–86 kg)

Location W. to E. and
southern Africa

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



The spotted hyena is the largest hyena species. The female is some 10 percent larger than the male, and her external sexual organs are enlarged so that they are difficult to distinguish from the male's. The social system is female-dominated and based on the clan, which varies from 5 or fewer adults and young in deserts to 50 or more in

prey-rich savanna. The clan, up to 80 individuals, occupies a communal den, uses communal latrines, and jointly defends its territory of 15–390 square miles (40–1,000 square km), delineated by calls, scent marking, and boundary patrols. The spotted hyena makes many sounds, including whoops, to rally its group or locate cubs, and the famous hyena's "laugh," to signify submission to a senior clan member.

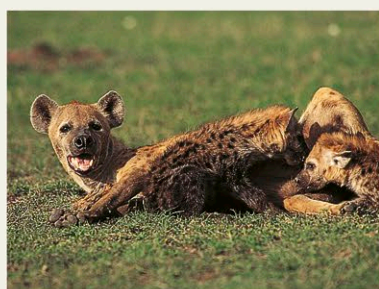
short,
rounded ears

REVERSED MANE

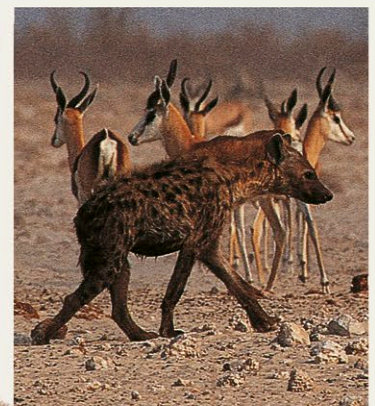
The spotted hyena's neck and back mane is reversed and the erectile hairs slope forward rather than back, standing erect when the hyena is excited.

SIBLING RIVALRY

The spotted hyena mother is solely responsible for cub rearing; the male plays no part. The average litter is 2 (range 1–3), born after 100 days' gestation and weaned at 14–18 months, when nearly full grown. The dominant cub controls access to the mother when suckling and, in times of milk shortage, may kill its sister or brother to improve its own chance of survival.

**HUNTING HYENA**

The spotted hyena is a powerful hunter. Several clan members may form a pack to bring down large prey, such as an adult zebra or wildebeest. When hunting alone, it catches hares, ground birds, and fish in shallows and swamps. It gorges on food, and is able to consume up to one-third of its body weight at one meal.



sandy to gray-
brown coat
with dark
spots that
fade with age



relatively long
front legs